



ONLINE ETIQUETTE 101

Here's what could cost you a future job, what you shouldn't do and what you should



WHAT CAN COST YOU A FUTURE JOB

- Provocative or inappropriate photographs, videos or information
- Information about drinking or using drugs in public
- Discriminatory comments related to race, gender or religion
- Bad-mouthing previous/current employer or fellow employee
- Abusive language/bigotry/hate speech
- Overtly political, religious or militant views

DON'T



- Scrub off all online presence. It can alarm potential employers
- Air radical views on public forums like social media sites
- Post something online that you don't want to be seen by an employer

DO



- Audit your profiles to make sure they reflect a positive version of you
- Assume that potential employers will comb through your entire social media history

sometimes to seek clarification on concerning posts. "If they posted or commented about something, I will just pick that up in the interview I will have with them," says Dwivedy. At other times, it comes in handy to understand the candidate beyond their CV. "If he likes music, it gives me a new dimension about him although it is not required for the job... Post-joining dissonance is lesser if I get to know the candidate better," says CIEL's Mishra.

Hiring decisions, however, don't entirely hinge on social media presence. K. Sudarshan, Regional Managing Partner (Asia) and MD of EMA Partners India, says it is premature to assess the cultural fitment of a candidate based just on what they have posted online. Recruiters accord it varying degrees of importance, but only in conjunction with other more objective assessment tools. But the findings, if serious enough, can prove to

be deal-breakers. "He could be a great guy, but he is not the guy for us," says Luthra, adding that she has rejected candidates on the basis of their social media posts.

RED FLAGS AND REJECTION

Luthra and Sinha both agree that it doesn't happen often, though. Overtly political/religious/militant views on social media sites are among the top offences in the eyes of recruiters. "As an organisation, we want to come across as being politically neutral because the company has to thrive no matter who is in power," says Randstad India's Raghuvanshi. Abusive language, bigotry and hate speech, sexism, misogyny, inappropriate sexual behaviour including gestures, alcohol or drug abuse, bad-mouthing previous/current employer or fellow employees in the form of photos or text can all drive away potential recruiters from your profile, they say.

But you may want to press pause on plans of scrubbing away all your evidence from the cyberworld. Having no digital footprint is a red flag on its own, too. The Express Employment survey found that among those using social networking to research candidates, more than half (55 per cent) found content that caused them not to hire the applicant. But 21 per cent said they are not likely to consider a candidate who doesn't have an online presence.

"They may not be active on social media, but they have a profile, a few friends, some likes, etc. If they don't, that scares me a little bit about where this person is coming from," says Luthra. Sudarshan points out that it is no longer a matter of pride to say you are not available on social media. "If you're a CXO and say that, it's a cause for concern actually," he says. CIEL's Mishra says that he looks for work-related posts. "The fact is working people spend 60 per cent of their active life in employment. If you have never been able to talk about it in your social circles, then it's something to really think about." The way to go about it, the experts say, is to have a positive social media presence.

BIASES AND PRIVACY

But there are pitfalls for recruiters, too. Biases creep in against the candidate even before they appear for an interview. "It is highly subjective and the system is already riddled with a lot of biases," says Talent500's Ahuja, who cautions recruiters against social media screening for cultural fitment. Agrees Luthra, adding that the sooner you do it in the process without meeting the person, the likelihood of you not forwarding a candidature because of your bias is much higher than